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MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM

MGU-UGP (HONOURS) REGULAR EXAMINATION NOVEMBER 2025

FIRST SEMESTER

Multi-Disciplinary Courses (MDC) - MG1MDCAGD100 - HISTORY OF ART & DESIGN

(2024 ADMISSION ONWARDS)

Part A

Short Answer Questions
Answer any 5 out of 7 Questions
Each Question carries 2 marks

1. Explain the significance of the Stele of Hammurabi in Mesopotamian art and culture.

   The Stele of Hammurabi is significant because it contains the earliest known written set of laws, establishing the Rule of Law in Mesopotamian culture and promoting civic unity. Artistically, the large stone monument served as a symbol of royal and divine authority, featuring a relief sculpture that depicts King Hammurabi receiving power from the sun god Shamash, which reinforced the king's right to rule and reflected the Mesopotamian values of order and hierarchy through its rigid, formal style.

2. List two characteristics of Rajput painting.

   They often showed themes from Hindu mythology, epics, and folklore, such as Krishna’s life, love stories, and festivals. The style is characterized by the use of bright colors, bold lines, flat backgrounds, and nature symbols.

3. Explain Lithographic printing.

   Lithography is a printmaking method that uses a flat printing surface, such as limestone, on which the image is drawn with a grease-based crayon. The surface is chemically treated so that the printing ink adheres only to the greasy image areas, while the non-image areas absorb water and repel the ink. For multi-colored prints, a separate stone is required for each color, necessitating precise alignment as the print goes through the press multiple times.

4. Recall the themes and colour of Mysore paintings.

   The themes of Mysore paintings are mostly religious, depicting Hindu gods and goddesses, and scenes from the Ramayana, Mahabharata, and Bhagavata Purana. The style is known for using soft colors, detailed work, and the application of natural colors and pure gold foil, which gives the paintings a rich and glowing effect.

5. State the key characteristic of Byzantine architecture.

   The use of central domes supported by pendentives, which is considered the most iconic feature, symbolizes the heavens and enables vast, awe-inspiring interiors.

6. Describe the term Ziggurats.

   Ziggurats were massive, stepped temple towers built from mud bricks by ancient Mesopotamian civilizations. They served as important religious centers with a temple at the top dedicated to a patron god, symbolizing a bridge between heaven and earth. Their monumental architectural form reflected the significance of religion and the advanced organization of the society.

7. Explain the contribution of Caravaggio to Baroque art.

   Caravaggio's primary contributions to Baroque art were his revolutionary use of dramatic light and shadow known as tenebrism to heighten emotional impact, his commitment to uncompromising realism by depicting subjects with lifelike detail, and his focus on emotional and psychological intensity. His style influenced a generation of European painters and helped establish the core characteristics of Baroque painting.

Part B

Short Essay Questions

Answer any 5 out of 7 Questions

Each Question carries 5 marks

8. Show the art which causes the illusion in a neat diagram and identify the art movement.

   The art that causes illusions is best exemplified by the Op Art (Optical Art) movement. Op Art features abstract, geometric, and repetitive patterns designed specifically to create illusions, such as movement, depth, fading, swelling, or vibration, tricking the eye and mind into perceiving things not actually present.

   The Associated Art Movement
   - Name: Op Art (Optical Art)
   - Origins: Gained popularity in the 1960s but has roots in earlier geometric abstraction.
   - Artists: Victor Vasarely, Bridget Riley, Jesús Rafael Soto, and others.
   - Features: Use of patterns, lines, and colors to disrupt visual perception, causing illusions of movement, flashing, and warping.

9. Recognize the influence of Mughal and Japanese styles in Abanindranath Tagore's paintings.

   Abanindranath Tagore stands as a pivotal figure in the history of Modern Indian Art, renowned as a pioneering artist and the founder of the influential Bengal

School of Art. His principal contribution was the movement to revive Indian artistic traditions in the early 20th century, steering them away from the dominant Western academic realism of the time.

Tagore consciously rejected the European approach, developing a distinct style deeply influenced by indigenous and Eastern art forms. Specifically, his work drew inspiration from Mughal, Rajput, and Japanese wash techniques. This fusion resulted in a focus on spiritual and nationalistic themes, emphasizing Indian identity and cultural pride.

His most famous works, such as Bharat Mata and The Passing of Shah Jahan, embody this shift from realism to symbolism. Bharat Mata, in particular, became an icon of the nationalist movement, depicting India as a nurturing and divine mother figure through Hindu goddess imagery and symbolic objects. Through his artistic vision, Abanindranath Tagore fostered a cultural renaissance and laid the essential foundation for modern Indian painting, ensuring its roots remained firmly connected to traditional heritage while embracing a new context.

10. Examining the key developments from traditional woodblock printing to modern digital printing, highlighting technological advancements and their impact on the print industry.

    The journey of printing, from traditional woodblock carving to contemporary digital methods, is a testament to technological innovation and its profound impact on human communication and industry. This evolution has been marked by a relentless pursuit of speed, efficiency, and the ability to reproduce information accurately and affordably for the masses.

    The earliest major development was woodblock printing, originating in ancient China over two millennia ago. This relief technique, where ink is applied to raised, carved surfaces, enabled the first forms of mass text and image reproduction, playing a crucial role in disseminating religious and scholarly works. This era of manual, labor-intensive reproduction was shattered by the advent of movable metal type and the printing press, most famously realized by Johannes Gutenberg in the mid-15th century. This invention industrialized the process, drastically reducing the cost of books and fueling the rapid spread of knowledge that defined the Renaissance.

    The next seismic shift occurred during the Industrial Revolution with the introduction of mechanical presses. Steam-powered machines like the rotary press enabled continuous, high-speed printing, transitioning the industry from craft to large-scale manufacturing. This capacity for immense production volumes became the bedrock of modern newspapers and mass-market publishing.

    Today, the industry is dominated by digital printing, which bypasses the need for physical plates by transferring images directly from a computer file to the printing surface via inkjet or laser technology. This final, revolutionary advancement has

brought unprecedented customization and speed. Digital methods excel at on-demand printing, short runs, and variable data printing, allowing every single printed item to be unique.

11. Demonstrate Raphael’s contributions to Renaissance art. How did his pursuit of harmony and classical ideals set him apart from his contemporaries?

    Raphael's contributions to Renaissance art include his role as a leading painter and architect of the High Renaissance, known for creating influential masterpieces such as The School of Athens and numerous Madonna paintings. He also served as chief architect of St. Peter's Basilica and helped preserve classical Roman architecture.

    His pursuit of harmony and classical ideals set him apart from his contemporaries, Leonardo da Vinci and Michelangelo, in the following ways -

    Clarity and Harmony
    - Raphael's paintings are renowned for their clarity, balance, and harmonious composition, employing proportion and symmetry so that everything fits together smoothly. This serene, harmonious style, coupled with a humanist spirit, created works known for their elegance.

    Ideal Beauty and Serenity
    - While all High Renaissance artists pursued ideal beauty, Raphael's approach resulted in figures with a lifelike presence and a sense of peace. He advanced painting with innovative techniques like soft, blended colors and subtle modeling to create a naturalism and beauty that was calm and clear. This contrasts with Leonardo's scientific realism and atmospheric sfumato, and Michelangelo's focus on monumental scale, intense emotional expression, and powerful, often heroic, ideal forms.

    Lasting Influence
    - His balanced and elegant style shaped academic art training and influenced European art from the Renaissance through the 19th century, setting a standard for beauty and naturalism.

12. Write a note on Pablo Picasso and recall his works.

    Pablo Picasso was a key figure in 20th-century art, best known as one of the founders of Cubism. Cubism broke away from traditional perspective, representing objects from multiple viewpoints simultaneously using geometric shapes.:

    Guernica (1937) - One of his most famous and powerful paintings, created as a response to the bombing of the Spanish town of Guernica during the Spanish Civil War. It is a universal symbol against war and violence, painted in black, white, and gray.

    Girl With Mandolin (1910) - An example of his work during the Cubism movement.

13. Discuss the role of advertising in shaping graphic design trends during the 20th century and how it influenced consumer culture.

    The role of advertising in shaping graphic design trends, particularly in the latter half of the 20th century, was fundamentally changed by technological and digital media innovations, which also influenced consumer culture.

    Digital Transformation - The introduction of computers and digital tools, such as desktop publishing software in the 1980s, revolutionized the creation and editing of visuals, allowing for greater precision and flexibility in design for commercial and advertising purposes. This made the production of advertising materials faster and cheaper.

    Expansion Beyond Print - Digital media expanded the scope of graphic design for advertising beyond traditional print into new forms like websites, television, and mobile devices, blending visual design with interactivity and motion, which became crucial for online communication and branding.

    Influence on Consumer Culture - The rise of social media further shaped online behavior. Marketing, customer engagement, and brand promotion shifted heavily toward these digital platforms, which led to the creation of new strategies like influencer culture and targeted advertising, fundamentally reshaping how consumers interact with and are marketed to by brands.

14. Recognize the cultural significance of Raja Ravi Varma's murals.

    The cultural significance of Raja Ravi Varma’s work is profound, earning him the title “Father of Modern Indian Art.” His murals and paintings marked a transformative moment by pioneering a unique fusion of traditions. Varma skillfully blended Western oil painting techniques, such as European realism, perspective, and shading, with Indian themes, particularly from Hindu mythology and the epics. This synthesis created a new visual idiom that set the standard for how deities and mythological scenes were depicted across India.

    Beyond aesthetics, his greatest cultural contribution was the democratization of art. By establishing a lithographic press, Varma made high-quality reproductions of his religious paintings widely accessible to the general public. These prints brought sacred art into everyday homes, challenging class and caste hierarchies that had previously restricted fine art to the elite.

    Furthermore, his art became a vital force in shaping modern Indian identity. His portrayals of mythological figures in humanized, relatable forms reinforced a sense of cultural pride and continuity during colonial rule. Varma's widely circulated imagery profoundly impacted India's collective imagination, influencing modern literature, film, and visual culture, securing his lasting legacy as a bridge between traditional and modern, sacred and secular art forms.

Part C

Essay Type Questions

Answer any 1 Question

Each Question carries 15 marks

15. Identify and explain the artistic techniques used in the Chauvet Cave paintings and Altamira cave paintings.

The Paleolithic artists of the Chauvet and Altamira caves employed remarkably sophisticated techniques that underscore the depth of early human artistic skill and symbolic thought. A comparison of the methods used at these two iconic sites reveals both shared practices and distinct approaches to creating what are considered the first masterpieces of art history.

Artistic Techniques in Chauvet Cave

Dating back approximately 30,000-36,000 years, the paintings in Chauvet Cave demonstrate advanced techniques that achieve exceptional realism and movement.

Materials and Pigments

- Artists primarily utilized charcoal for black outlines and shading, and ochre for red areas. This limited palette was expertly manipulated to create complex effects.

Shading and Depth

- A defining technique at Chauvet was the skillful use of shading and blending (chiaroscuro) to give figures volume and depth, a quality previously thought to have developed much later.

Engraving and Painting Combination

- Images were often created by scratching lines (engraving) into the rock, which was then combined with painting to enhance the contours and visual impact of the animals.

Tools and Application

- The application of color was performed using brushes made from hair or moss, along with fingers and the technique of blown pigment. The walls themselves were also carefully prepared before the artwork was created.

Perspective and Movement

- The artists employed an understanding of perspective and anatomical accuracy to depict animals like cave lions, mammoths, and horses with lifelike movement, often capturing multiple legs to suggest motion.

Artistic Techniques in Altamira Cave

Altamira Cave, known as the 'Sistine Chapel of Prehistoric Art, showcases paintings dating back at least 14,000 years, characterized by their vivid color and

three-dimensional appearance, particularly on the famous ceiling of polychrome bison.

Polychrome Painting

- Unlike Chauvet's more limited palette, Altamira artists were masters of polychrome painting, utilizing a range of natural mineral pigments like ochre for red and yellow, charcoal and manganese for black to layer colors, add depth, and achieve tone.

Exploitation of Natural Relief

- A key technique was the skillful use of the cave's natural curves and bulges to create a compelling three-dimensional effect. By painting over these natural rock formations, the artists made the bison and other large mammals appear lifelike and in motion.

Shading and Outline

- Shading and perspective were applied carefully to enhance the sense of volume and movement. The artists used engraving and outlining to further clarify and define the forms of the animals.

Surface Preparation and Dilution

- Artists prepared the wall surfaces and also diluted pigments to control the color intensity, creating light-and-shadow effects that contribute to the realism of the images.

Application Methods

- Pigments were applied using tools like fingers, brushes, and twigs, or dispersed by blowing them through hollow bones to achieve a spray effect.

Both Chauvet and Altamira artists demonstrated a foundational understanding of key artistic principles. They used natural mineral pigments, employed engraving alongside painting, and utilized fingers or improvised brushes for application. However, Chauvet is remarkable for its early mastery of shading and perspective, creating a striking sense of realism with a more limited palette, while Altamira is celebrated for its mastery of polychrome painting and its unique technique of incorporating the cave's natural three-dimensional relief to bring the paintings to life. Together, these sites provide crucial evidence of the creative genius and advanced technical capabilities of Upper Paleolithic humans.

16. Summarize the symbolic motifs employed in Warli paintings and their connection to tribal rituals and social hierarchy.

Warli painting, a traditional tribal art form from Maharashtra, is deeply rooted in the symbolic motifs that reflect the Warli tribe's close relationship with nature and their community rituals. The art is defined by its austere simplicity, using only basic geometric shapes like the circle, triangle, and square to depict all elements of their world. These shapes are not merely artistic conventions but carry profound

symbolic meaning. The circle represents the sun and the moon, embodying the cycle of nature; the triangle signifies mountains and trees; and the square is used for the sacred enclosure or piece of land.

The themes of Warli paintings are intrinsically connected to tribal rituals and daily life, acting as a visual storytelling mechanism. The murals frequently illustrate festivals, rituals, farming, hunting, and village life, with a common spiritual reverence for the Mother Goddess and nature. The figures are often shown in rhythmic group patterns, such as during dances, highlighting the communal and social aspects of tribal existence. While the paintings do not explicitly detail social hierarchy, they serve to preserve and communicate the tribe's worldview, communal activities, and core religious values, affirming the bond between the people, their land, and the spiritual world. This blend of simple form and rich, ritualistic content makes Warli art a powerful record of their cultural identity.

17. Explain the development of the Internet from its early roots in ARPANET to the global system we know today.

    The development of the Internet is a story of revolutionary communication, tracing its roots from a Cold War defense project to the indispensable global network of today.

    The journey began in the late 1960s with the ARPANET (Advanced Research Projects Agency Network), a pioneering project by the U.S. Department of Defense's ARPA. Its creation was driven by the need for a communication system that could remain functional even if parts of it were destroyed in an attack during the Cold War. To achieve this reliability, ARPANET employed packet switching, a method that breaks data into small units, or "packets," which can travel independently along different routes before being reassembled at the destination. The first message, partially sent on October 29, 1969, between computers at UCLA and Stanford Research Institute, marked the foundational step in Internet history, demonstrating the feasibility of long-distance computer-to-computer communication.

    As the network grew, a standardized communication method became necessary. This led to the adoption of TCP/IP (Transmission Control Protocol/Internet Protocol). This protocol suite defines how data is divided, sent, routed, and reassembled, ensuring reliable and ordered data transfer between different devices and networks. TCP/IP is the backbone that allows all devices on the Internet to communicate smoothly, defining the core structure of the "network of networks."

    The next major leap transformed the Internet from a research tool into a public utility: the invention of the World Wide Web (WWW). Created at CERN by Tim Berners-Lee in 1989, the Web is a system of interlinked web pages and online resources accessible via a web browser. It utilized HTML (HyperText Markup Language) for creating pages, URLs (Uniform Resource Locators) for unique

addresses, and HTTP (HyperText Transfer Protocol) for communication between browsers and servers. While the Internet is the physical network, the World Wide Web is the system that made information browsing, reading, and interaction easy and intuitive, turning the network into the global information tool it is today.

Simultaneously, the rise of computers and digital tools in the 20th century, particularly with the introduction of desktop publishing and software like Adobe Photoshop and Illustrator in the 1980s, drove a fundamental shift toward digital design, further accelerating the need for and growth of the Internet.

In its modern form, the Internet's evolution has been profoundly shaped by social media. Platforms like Facebook, Instagram, and X have made the Internet more interactive and community-driven, transforming online behavior from passive consumption to active creation and sharing of content. Social media has become a primary driver of Internet usage, redefining its purpose from a purely informational tool to a dynamic space for communication, collaboration, and social interaction, cementing its role as an indispensable part of daily life and global commerce.

In summary, the journey of the Internet from the resilient packet-switching of ARPANET to the standardizing power of TCP/IP, and then the user-friendly interface of the World Wide Web, ultimately resulted in the globally connected system that underpins modern communication, culture, and business.